

RAAZIA IMRAN

SOFTWARE ENGINEERING

ROLL # 09

FUNCTIONAL ENGLISH

EA-104

THE ONLY AMERICAN FROM OUR VILLAGE BY ARUN JOSHI

SUMMARY:

The short story follows Dr. Khanna, an outstanding immigrant physicist at the University of Wisconsin, who returns to India at 40. Dr. Khanna, his wife Joanne, and their two sons visit India, where he lived for 15 years, where his fame had preceded him.

A four-week trip to the village was a success, where officials from the Council of Scientific Research recognized his achievements. He attended a conference on interplanetary radiation and was offered many jobs. His wife and children were worshipped by his relatives, who had never met before. An old

man, Ashtamp Farosh, came to see Dr. Khanna, who was embarrassed by his accent. The old man mentioned his close relationship with Dr. Khanna's father. Dr. Khanna's father won a scholarship and went to Lahore to pursue a college degree. The villager met Dr. Khanna's father every summer. After his mother's death, he left the village. After retiring, he was happy and proud of his children. He said it was an honor to be the only American from their village; it was his son. Then the ashtamp Farosh questioned Dr. Khanna about why he didn't send Kundan Lal a ticket to America, with Dr. Khanna explaining he couldn't afford it. The ashtamp farosh recalls Kundan Lal's poverty, detailing his struggles, such as crossing hot sand without shoes, highlighting his difficult life.

Kundan Lal, after retiring, changed his habits in anticipation of a ticket to America, which he believed Dr. Khanna would send. This hope led him to shave daily, buy new clothes, and become more religious. However, the ticket never came, leaving him disappointed and affecting his behavior. He eventually recovered and was able to go home. In the month of May, on a very hot day, KundanLaal went on a trip, and on the very next day he died.

The Khanna family boarded a plane for Chicago, and Khanna's wife was upset with her husband's behavior and believed that Khanna was staring at his feet the whole time. Dr. Khanna, despite being a respected figure in his field, was then known for his lack of research output, which had been zero.

CRITICAL POINT OF VIEW:

The story explores into themes of cultural expectations, personal responsibility, and the impact of promises. Dr. Khanna's return to his village highlights the gap between his global success and his unclear connections to his past. Despite his significant achievements in the field of physics, Dr. Khanna's personal relationships and promises are left unresolved. The story explores the cultural and emotional disconnection between Dr. Khanna and his Indian roots. The story ends with an emotional reminder of the difficulties of juggling one's past and present, as well as the personal and emotional price of professional achievement. Dr. Khanna's travel back to India and subsequent return to America highlight the internal conflicts he suffers.

From my perspective, the story highlights the conflict between Dr. Khanna's outstanding professional achievements and the unresolved personal ties he left behind. His return to his village reveals the emotional and cultural divide between his past and present, emphasizing the personal cost of his achievement. The story skillfully brings out how promises and cultural expectations may weigh heavily on an individual, causing significant reflection on the sacrifices made in pursuit of excellence.

